SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #107 · SUFFERING

# “Real Christians don’t suffer.”

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## Where it often comes from

Teaching that faith brings a trouble-free life. Prosperity messages that promise health and success. Seeing your suffering as proof you are not a true believer. Comparing your hardships with other Christians’ apparent ease. Feeling betrayed by God when hard times came.

## What Scripture teaches

Scripture says the opposite: all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted. It has been granted to believers not only to believe in Christ but also to suffer for Him. Believers throughout the world undergo the same kinds of suffering. Hebrews describes faithful people who were mistreated and destitute; the world was not worthy of them. Suffering is part of the Christian life, and after a little while, God Himself will restore, strengthen, and establish you.

> *“Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted”* **(2 Timothy 3:12)**.

## Also see

> “For it has been granted to you on behalf of Christ not only to believe in Him, but also to suffer for Him” **(Philippians 1:29)**.

> “Resist him, standing firm in your faith and in the knowledge that your brothers throughout the world are undergoing the same kinds of suffering. And after you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you” **(1 Peter 5:9–10)**.

> “I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!” **(John 16:33)**.

> “They were stoned, they were sawed in two, they were put to death by the sword. They went around in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, oppressed, and mistreated. The world was not worthy of them. They wandered in deserts and mountains, and hid in caves and holes in the ground” **(Hebrews 11:37–38)**.

## Common self-statements

- If I were a real Christian, I wouldn’t be going through this.
- My suffering proves my faith is fake.
- Other Christians don’t suffer like I do.
- God promised me an easy life.
- Something is wrong with my faith.
- Faith should protect me from pain.

## Common logical errors

- **Mental filter:** Overlooking the suffering of faithful people throughout Scripture.
- **Comparison:** Comparing your hardships with other Christians’ outward lives.
- **Labeling:** Calling yourself a fake Christian because you suffer.
- **Misunderstanding the gospel:** Believing faith guarantees a pain-free life.

## Challenging questions

- What does 2 Timothy 3:12 say about godly people?
- What has been granted to believers, according to Philippians 1:29?
- Are believers around the world suffering too?
- Did the people of faith in Hebrews 11 suffer?
- Did Jesus promise an easy life?
- What does God promise after suffering, according to 1 Peter 5:10?
- How might God be with me in my suffering?

## Truth summary

> Real Christians do suffer. Scripture says godly people will face persecution and hardship, and faithful believers throughout history have suffered. My suffering does not mean my faith is fake. After a little while, the God of all grace will restore, strengthen, and establish me.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- Persecution
- Hardship
- Faith
- Strength

**Godly Counsel Lessons:**

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Persecution
- Trouble/Hardship

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Real Christians don't suffer"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

**Name:** _____ **Date started:** _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

**"Real Christians don't suffer."** I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What does 2 Timothy 3:12 say?
- ☐ What has been granted to believers?
- ☐ Are believers worldwide suffering too?
- ☐ Did the faithful in Hebrews 11 suffer?
- ☐ Did Jesus promise an easy life?
- ☐ What does God promise after suffering?

**My own question:** _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Real Christians do suffer.
- ☐ My suffering does not mean my faith is fake.
- ☐ Believers everywhere face hardships.
- ☐ God will restore, strengthen, and establish me.
- ☐ Jesus has overcome the world.
- ☐ The world was not worthy of suffering saints.

**In my own words:** _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- [ ] **2 Timothy 3:12**
  *"Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted."*
- [ ] **Philippians 1:29**
  *"For it has been granted to you on behalf of Christ not only to believe in Him, but also to suffer for Him."*
- [ ] **1 Peter 5:9–10**
  *"Resist him, standing firm in your faith and in the knowledge that your brothers throughout the world are undergoing the same kinds of suffering. And after you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you."*
- [ ] **John 16:33**
  *"I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!"*
- [ ] **Hebrews 11:37–38**
  *"They were stoned, they were sawed in two, they were put to death by the sword. They went around in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, oppressed, and mistreated. The world was not worthy of them. They wandered in deserts and mountains, and hid in caves and holes in the ground."*

**A verse I found myself:** _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Fellowship of suffering log:** Each day, write one way I am not alone in my suffering: Jesus, Scripture, or other believers.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 1 Peter 5:10 becomes: "And after **Sarah** has suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called **her** to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore **her**, secure **her**, strengthen **her**, and establish **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- ☐ **Read Hebrews 11 and 12:1–3,** and write how faithful people endured hardship.
- ☐ **Learn about one persecuted Christian or church today,** and pray for them.
- ☐ **Tell a trusted believer about your suffering,** and ask how they have suffered as a Christian.
- ☐ **Write a short prayer of trust** for each hard thing you are facing.

**What I will do:** _____

**When:** _____

**What the lie predicts will happen:** _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

**What actually happened:** _____

**What I learned:** _____

**The lie** "Real Christians don't suffer": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | One way I am not alone |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Real Christians don't suffer.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord Jesus, You suffered, and You told me I would have trouble in this world. Help me reject the lie that real Christians don't suffer. Strengthen my faith in hard times, remind me that I am not alone, and restore and establish me in Your time. In Your name, Amen.*

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*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*